

The credential you do not hold is the schedule you cannot keep

Portable IDs and licenses a WLAN pro carries from job to job, sorted by lead time. Some you cannot obtain on the day you need them - scope them before you quote, not after you win.

LEAD TIME (PLAN-AHEAD)	CREDENTIAL	ISSUING AUTHORITY	WHERE IT GATES YOU	VALIDITY
MONTHS NACI can run many months	CAC	DoD (sponsor required)	DoD-affiliated contractors with an ongoing need on military installations and networks.	~3 yr / contract
WEEKS Enroll ≥60 days ahead; processing can exceed 45 days	TWIC	TSA / USCG (under MTSA)	Unescorted access to secure areas of maritime facilities and vessels - ports, terminals, container yards.	5 years
WEEKS ~7–10 days to ~3 weeks	SIDA badge	Airport authority (under TSA)	Unescorted access to the airport airside / Security Identification Display Area .	Per airport
WEEKS Vetting, then 180 days to obtain the physical card	DBIDS	DoD installation (DMDC)	Contractors / vendors needing base access without a CAC .	Per installation
FAST / DAYS 40-hr course + 3 days supervised field	HAZWOPER 40-hr	Employer (OSHA 1910.120)	Site workers at hazardous-waste cleanup / uncontrolled sites.	Cert; 8-hr annual refresh
FAST / DAYS Days to a few weeks	School / corrections check	State / district (or DOC)	Contractors with regular / unsupervised student contact ; cleared correctional access.	Per state / district
FAST / DAYS One-time exam you can go pass	GROL	FCC (via a COLEM)	Not needed for Wi-Fi or licensed microwave - only if you also service aviation / marine radios.	Issued for life

FCC MYTH-BUST You probably do not need an FCC operator license. An operator license (GROL) is not the same as equipment authorization (Part 15 cert) or an amateur (ham) license - and unlicensed Wi-Fi **and** licensed point-to-point microwave backhaul (Part 101) need none of them. A GROL only matters if you also service aviation or marine radios.